Welcome, and a Note About How I Teach

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I am writing this so you know the kind of classroom you have walked into, and so you can decide, on day one, whether the way I teach is the way you want to learn. I think it will be. But I want you to choose it with both eyes open.

Here is the first thing to know about me. I am a language nut. Portuguese for fifteen years (most of it picked up in Brazilian restaurants in Massachusetts, with Rosetta Stone helping on the side). Spanish for fifteen. French for ten. Japanese for eight. Mandarin for five, including a year of living and teaching in Qingdao that mostly taught me how much I did not know. I tell you this not to flex but to confess: I am the learner sitting next to you. I know what it feels like to want to say something and have your brain stall halfway across the bridge. I know the small dignity of a sentence you finally get out, and the bigger dignity of getting it wrong and laughing.

Here is the second thing. I am not interested in getting you across a finish line. I am interested in getting you to love the marathon.

What does that look like in our class? Plenty of specific things.

It means I will not be the teacher who hands you the answer. I will build up to it with you, ask questions, sometimes too many, and call on you when you did not raise your hand. No coasting. There is too much to gain. I will learn your name before I learn what you already know about English, because the first thing matters more. I will give extensions when you need them, and I will tell you, gently and specifically, where you can push. I would rather you produce a real thing (a podcast episode, a poem, a paragraph you actually meant) than ace a worksheet you forget by Friday.

It means I will treat the so-called rules of English less like dogma and more like a groove you are learning to feel. There are patterns; you will internalize them. But English is a hand-me-down from a thousand other languages and it contradicts itself constantly. Your job is not to memorize every exception. Your job is to develop an ear, an eye, an instinct, the same way a drummer learns the pocket: by playing in it badly until one day, without noticing, you are in it.

It means I will use whatever helps you specifically. Cross-linguistic comparisons (the speakers of Spanish, Portuguese, French, Japanese, and Mandarin in the room will hear me reach across). Music. Memes. Wikipedia wormholes. Custom examples written for you, on the spot, using the word you are stuck on and the topic you actually care about. I have spent the last two years building tools to make that kind of hyper-custom teaching possible, and I will use them with you, openly. They are not a shortcut around the work; they are an amplifier for it.

And it means I will admit, often, that I do not know. I started rowing a few months ago on the Charles River. My coach yells a command in rowing jargon and I want to yell back, “I am doing that!”, before I realize I am not. I am terrible at it. I love it. That is the posture I want you to bring to English: the willingness to be a beginner in public, the patience for your neurons to catch up, the curiosity to ask one more question when your brain is already tired.

Now, the marathon part.

Most of you will not “finish” learning English in this class. Neither will I, in any of the five languages I keep tending. The truth no one tells you in language school is that fluency is not a destination, it is a relationship. You will be in this relationship the rest of your life, and you get to decide what kind it is. I want you to decide it is one you enjoy. I want you to find the part of English that is yours: the song lyrics that finally click, the slang you can wield, the email you sent without rereading three times, the conversation with a stranger that went on longer than you thought it could. Those are the miles that compound. Those are why people keep running.

So here is the deal. Show up. Try things. Drop the ball and pick it up (my dad taught me to juggle in third grade, and the drop is the point, not the failure). Ask. Tinker. Be a little annoyed at me when I do not hand you the answer. Be a little proud of yourself when you find it.

I am glad you are here.

Kramer